The Division of the Empire

During the third century, a period referred to as the Imperial Crisis, Rome experienced civil war as numerous generals wrestled with each other to take the throne. People experienced one hardship after another because the economy was failing. The empire was eventually divided into three different areas. Diocletian brought these areas back together under his rule, which lasted between 284 and 305 CE. He introduced the Tetrarchy or the Rule of Four to ensure order could be maintained effectively. However, Diocletian discovered that the Empire had expanded so much that it was difficult to rule. He divided it into the Eastern Roman Empire and the Western Roman Empire in 285 CE, which allowed the whole territory to be effectively governed. Since much of the Imperial Crisis was caused by fighting over the next successor, he declared that a successor was required to be named as soon as the Emperor took the throne. In 305 CE, Diocletian volunteered to step down from his seat of power. When Diocletian died in 311 CE, his general Maxentius and successor Constantine thrust the empire back into a bloody civil war.